

Gruenfeld Defense

A controlled 5.Bf4 system against immediate pressure on the center

THE PROMISE

Meet the Gruenfeld with active development and a manageable branch tree, keeping the center only when it can be supported.

COURSE VOLUME 07 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Recognize ...d5 as the move that distinguishes the Gruenfeld from the King's Indian.
- Use Nf3 and Bf4 to develop before Black can force a favorable liquidation.
- Handle ...c5, ...c6, ...dxc4, ...Nh5, ...a6, and queen pressure on a5/c5.
- Understand when to preserve the center, exchange it, or return a pawn for development.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

01	The 5.Bf4 spine
02	Main ...c5 pressure
03	Solid ...c6 setup
04	Immediate ...c5 before castling
05	Black chases Bf4 with ...Nh5
06	Early ...dxc4
07	...a6 and queenside expansion
08	Move orders and anti-Gruenfeld attempts

Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

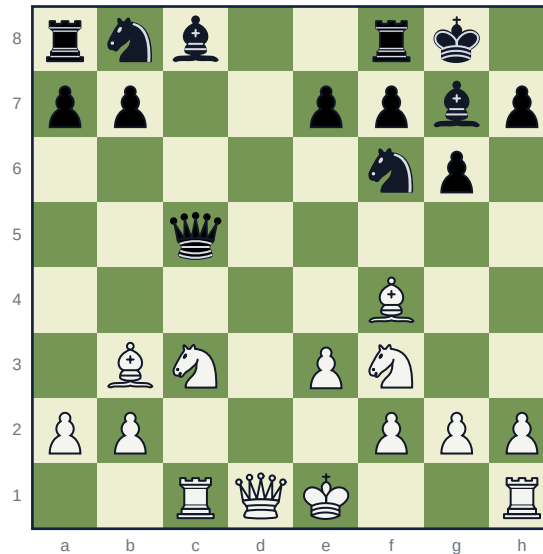
The 5.Bf4 spine

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5: Black attacks the center immediately.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Qa5 8. Rc1 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Qxc5 10. Bb3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White develops Nf3 and Bf4 before building e3, avoiding the heaviest Exchange-Variation theory while keeping pressure on c7/d6. Black's ...c5 challenges d4 and often brings the queen to a5 or c5. White may surrender the central pawn to complete development, then use piece activity and the bishop on f4. The repertoire values a healthy position over clinging to every pawn.

White's plan

- Develop Bf4 and e3; use Rc1 when the c-file and c-pawn exchanges make the rook active.
- Return or exchange a center pawn when doing so gains tempi on the queen and completes development.
- Use Be2, O-O, and Qe2/Rd1 to make d4/e3 secure before expanding.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks d4 and uses the g7 bishop against c3/b2.
- ...Qa5 pressures c5/c3 and can create checks on the diagonal.
- ...dxc4 removes a center support and opens the g7 bishop.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...O-O	6.e3. Build before deciding central exchanges.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...c5	7.dxc5 Qa5 8.Rc1; develop with tempo around the c-file.
6...c6	7.Be2 dxc4 8.Bxc4; keep a Slav-like center.
6...Nh5	7.Bg5 and preserve the bishop unless a favorable exchange appears.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The Gruenfeld punishes a center that is defended only by pawns. Every central pawn must be backed by pieces or exchanged before it becomes a tactical target.

MEMORY HOOK

Develop the pieces that defend the center; trade a pawn before it costs a tempo.

CHAPTER 02

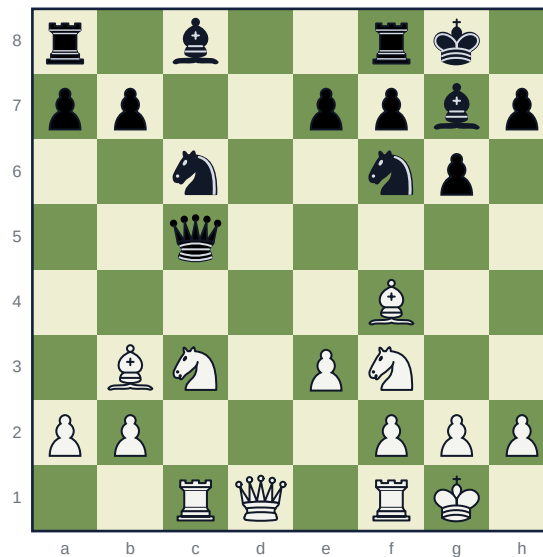
Main ...c5 pressure

POSITION TRIGGER

Black has castled and strikes d4 with ...c5 before White is fully developed.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Qa5 8. Rc1 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Qxc5 10. Bb3 Nc6 11. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White accepts central liquidation to finish development without structural damage. Bb3 preserves the active bishop and avoids queen tempi; castling ends the opening phase. The position is open, so piece activity and development outweigh small pawn-count fluctuations. Black's queen can be exposed to Ne4 or Na4 ideas, but White should not chase it unless the chase improves a piece.

White's plan

- Use Rc1 to connect rook pressure with the c-file exchanges.
- Develop O-O, Qe2, and Rfd1; use the open files before searching for pawn weaknesses.
- Challenge the queen with a developing move such as Ne4 when it gains a central square.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Nc6 develops and controls e5/d4 while protecting the queen's routes.
- ...Bg4 can pin Nf3 and increase pressure on d4/e2.
- ...Rd8 and ...Bf5 activate every piece in the open center.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...Qa5	8.Rc1 develops the rook into the tactical center.
8...dxc4	9.Bxc4; recover through development.
9...Qxc5	10.Bb3. Save the bishop while preparing to castle.
...Nc6	Castle; do not spend more tempi harassing the queen without a concrete gain.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

An active queen is not automatically misplaced. Attack it only with moves you wanted to play anyway.

MEMORY HOOK

Open center: complete development, then use tempi on the queen.

CHAPTER 03

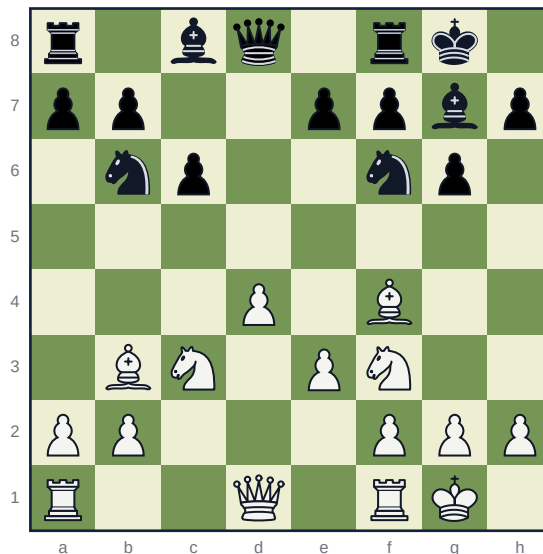
Solid ...c6 setup

POSITION TRIGGER

Black supports d5 with ...c6 and delays the direct ...c5 break.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c6 7. Be2 dxc4 8. Bxc4 Nbd7 9. O-O Nb6 10. Bb3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The structure resembles a Slav with Black's bishop fianchettoed. White develops Be2 and recovers c4 naturally. Black's ...Nbd7-b6 gains a tempo on the bishop and prepares ...Nfd5 or ...c5. White keeps the bishop on b3, completes Qe2/Rfd1, and uses e4 when the center is sufficiently supported.

White's plan

- Recover Bxc4 and preserve the bishop with Bb3 when ...Nb6 arrives.
- Prepare e4 with Qe2 and Rfd1; the center must withstand ...Nfd5 and ...c5.
- Use h3 to remove ...Bg4 only when the pin obstructs e4 or development.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Nbd7-b6 gains a tempo and places the knight against c4/d5.
- ...Nfd5 challenges Bf4 and increases central pressure.
- ...c5 is still Black's freeing break once development supports it.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...c6	7.Be2. Keep the setup simple and castle-ready.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...dxc4	8.Bxc4; natural recovery.
8...Nbd7	9.O-O Nb6 10.Bb3; preserve bishop and development.
...Nfd5	Bg3 or Be5; retain control of key central squares.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not rush e4 while Black can answer ...Nfd5 and win a tempo on Bf4. Add Qe2/Rfd1 first.

MEMORY HOOK

Solid ...c6: recover, castle, preserve bishop, then earn e4.

CHAPTER 04

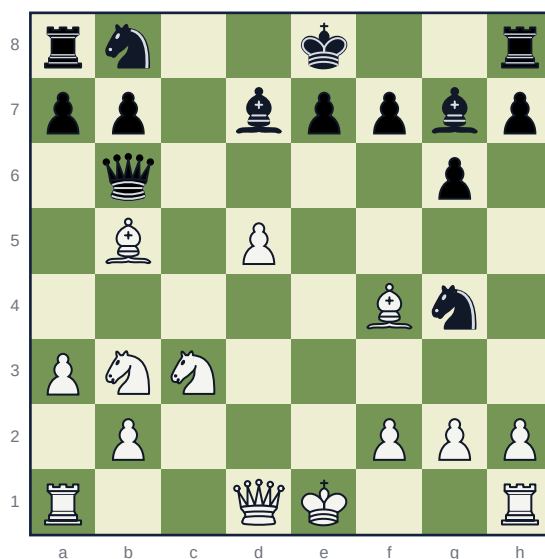
Immediate ...c5 before castling

POSITION TRIGGER

Black attacks d4 with ...c5 before committing the king.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 c5 6. dxc5 Qa5 7. Nd2 Qxc5 8. Nb3 Qxc4 9. e4 Qb4 10. a3 Qb6 11. exd5 Ng4 12. Bb5+ Bd7



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Nd2 keeps the c-file clear and supports e4; after the queen recovers on c5, Nb3 gains a useful tempo. White allows the queen to take c4 because 9.e4 opens the center against Black's uncastled king. a3 and Bb5+ force further development concessions. The line is concrete, but its logic is stable: use the queen's pawn hunting to gain central tempi and rapid piece activity.

White's plan

- Use Nd2-b3 to gain a queen tempo and support the e4 break.
- Open with e4 while Black's king remains uncastled and the queen is exposed.
- Use a3 and Bb5+ as developing tempi; castle as soon as the central tactics resolve.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Qa5 creates checks and pressures c5/c3.
- ...Qxc5 recovers the pawn while keeping queen activity.
- ...dxe4 can expose the d-file and test White's king before castling.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...c5	6.dxc5 makes Black spend a queen move to recover.
6...Qa5	7.Nd2 supports e4 and avoids blocking the c-file.
7...Qxc5	8.Nb3 gains a queen tempo before the central break.
...dxc4	Nxc4 or Bxc4 according to which develops with tempo on the queen.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not confuse an open center with a license to leave your own king there. Calculate checks first, then open lines.

MEMORY HOOK

Early ...c5: Nd2-b3 gains a queen tempo; e4 opens the center before Black castles.

CHAPTER 05

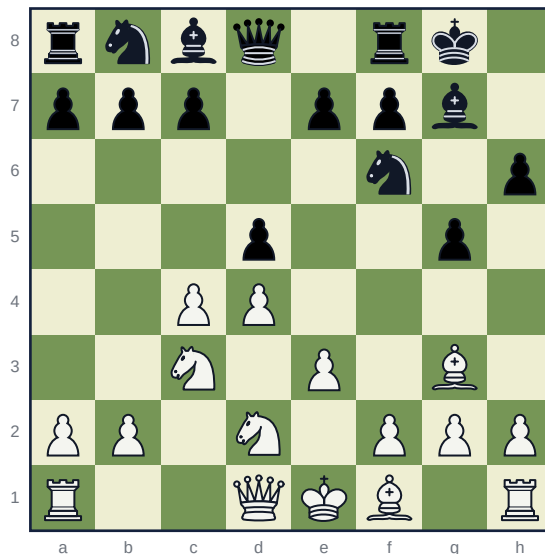
Black chases Bf4 with ...Nh5

POSITION TRIGGER

Black uses the f6 knight to attack the repertoire bishop before striking the center.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 Nh5 7. Bg5 h6 8. Bh4 g5 9. Nd2 Nf6 10. Bg3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The bishop retreats along the h2-b8 diagonal while Black loosens the kingside. Nd2 attacks h5/f3 routes and prepares Bg3. White should not try to punish the pawn advance instantly; first complete Be2, O-O, and h4 or Bg3. The weakened dark squares matter only if White's pieces can reach them before Black's center becomes active.

White's plan

- Preserve the bishop with Bg5-h4 when Black spends kingside pawn tempi.
- Use Nd2 and Bg3 to regroup, then complete Be2 and O-O.
- Challenge g5 with h4 only after calculating ...g4 and king exposure.

What Black is trying to do

- ...h6 and ...g5 gain bishop tempi and kingside space.
- ...c5 can strike the center while White's pieces are retreating.
- ...g4 may dislodge Nf3 and make the pawn expansion tactically sound.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Nh5	7.Bg5. Keep the bishop and provoke a decision.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...h6	8.Bh4; Black has weakened g6/h6.
8...g5	9.Nd2, preparing regrouping and pressure on the advanced pawns.
...c5	Solve the center before attacking the kingside pawns.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A weakening is not a target until you can attack it. Development and central stability come before h-pawn adventures.

MEMORY HOOK

Let Black spend pawn tempi; regroup, castle, then attack the fixed weakness.

CHAPTER 06

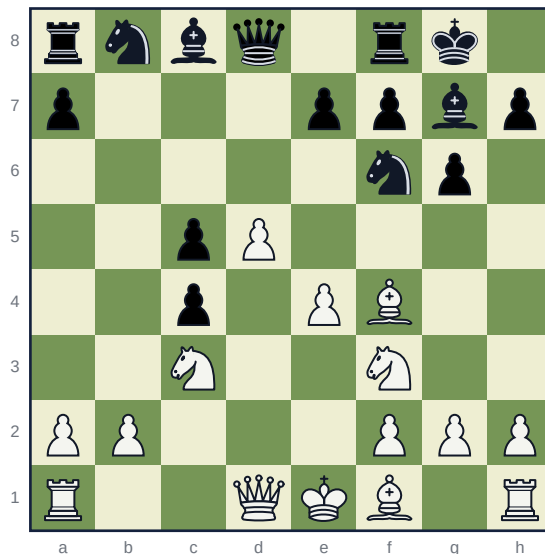
Early ...dxc4

POSITION TRIGGER

Black captures c4 before White completes e3/Be2 development.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 dxc4 6. e4 c5 7. d5 b5 8. Nxb5 O-O 9. Nc3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White occupies the center with e4 and uses d5 when Black counterattacks with ...c5. The pawn on c4 may be recovered later; central space and development are more urgent. The line can become sharp after ...b5, so the knight capture is justified only when the calculation confirms safe retreat and the king can castle. In quieter versions, Bxc4 after e3 is the preferred recovery.

White's plan

- Build e4 when Black's d-pawn leaves the center and the move is tactically safe.
- Use d5 against ...c5 to preserve space and restrict the g7 bishop.
- Recover c4 with Bxc4 or Nxb5 only when doing so does not delay king safety dangerously.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks d4/e4 and opens the g7 bishop.
- ...b5 supports c4 and gains queenside space.
- ...O-O and ...Qa5 create tactics against the uncastled king and c3 knight.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...dxc4	6.e4 claims the released center.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...c5	7.d5 keeps space and closes the g7 bishop.
7...b5	Calculate Nxb5 only if ...Qa5+ and queen checks are controlled.
...O-O	Retreat the knight and complete development; material is secondary to coordination.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

This is one of the course's concrete branches. If the exact tactic is not remembered, choose safe recovery with e3/Bxc4 rather than improvising a pawn raid.

MEMORY HOOK

Capture on c4 concedes center: occupy e4, meet ...c5 with d5, stay tactically awake.

CHAPTER 07

...a6 and queenside expansion

POSITION TRIGGER

Black inserts ...a6 and ...b5 to gain space while keeping central options.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 a6 7. Rc1 dxc4 8. Bxc4 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Rc1 anticipates c-file activity and makes Bxc4 recovery natural. Black's ...b5 gains space but leaves a6/b5 targets. White retreats Be2 and castles, then uses a4 or Ne5. The g7-b2 diagonal means queenside pawn breaks must be calculated with the rook and knight placement in mind.

White's plan

- Use Rc1 before recovery so the rook benefits from opened c-files.
- Retreat Be2 after ...b5 and castle; challenge b5 with a4 only when the file helps White.
- Use Ne5 and Bf3 to occupy central dark squares if Black's queenside pawns become fixed.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b5 gains bishop tempo and supports ...Bb7.
- ...Bb7 increases pressure on g2 and d5.
- ...c5 may follow after the queenside structure is secured.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...a6	7.Rc1 develops toward the likely c-file.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...dxc4	8.Bxc4. Recover through development.
8...b5	9.Be2; preserve bishop and castle.
...Bb7	O-O and a4/Ne5 according to whether b5 is stable.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not open the a-file while Black's rook is the first piece able to use it. Count which rook reaches the file and which pawn becomes weak.

MEMORY HOOK

Rc1 anticipates the file; recover, retreat, castle, then undermine.

CHAPTER 08

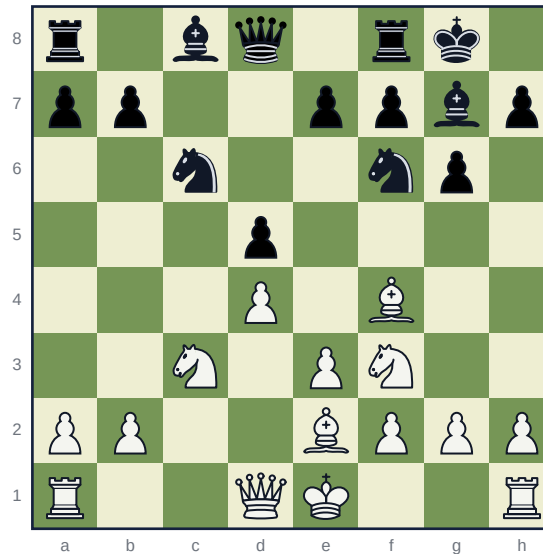
Move orders and anti-Gruenfeld attempts

POSITION TRIGGER

Black delays ...Bg7, inserts ...c6, or reaches ...d5 through a different order.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 c6 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Bf4 Nc6 7. e3 Bg7 8. Be2 O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

An early ...c6 allows cxd5 to create a symmetrical center where White's development and Bf4 give a clear plan. If Black reaches ...d5 after ...Bg7, the same Nf3/Bf4 setup applies. If Black never plays ...d5 and chooses ...d6/e5, switch to the King's Indian volume. The repertoire fork is the d-pawn, not the move number.

White's plan

- Against ...c6, exchange cxd5 when it prevents Black from building an ideal ...c5 break with one move.
- Develop Bf4, e3, Be2, and O-O in symmetrical centers.
- Switch immediately to King's Indian plans if Black uses ...d6/e5 instead of ...d5.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c6 supports d5 and prepares ...Bf5 or ...O-O.
- ...Nc6 increases pressure on d4 and may prepare ...Nh5.
- Move-order transpositions can change whether cxd5 is useful by improving Black's recapture.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...d5	4.Nf3 and 5.Bf4: Gruenfeld.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...c6	5.cxd5 cxd5 6.Bf4: symmetrical center.
3...Bg7 4.e4 d6	Use the King's Indian volume.
...c5 without ...d5	Advance d5 and use the Benoni map.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not classify by Black's fianchetto alone. The same bishop belongs to Gruenfeld, King's Indian, Benoni, and Modern structures.

MEMORY HOOK

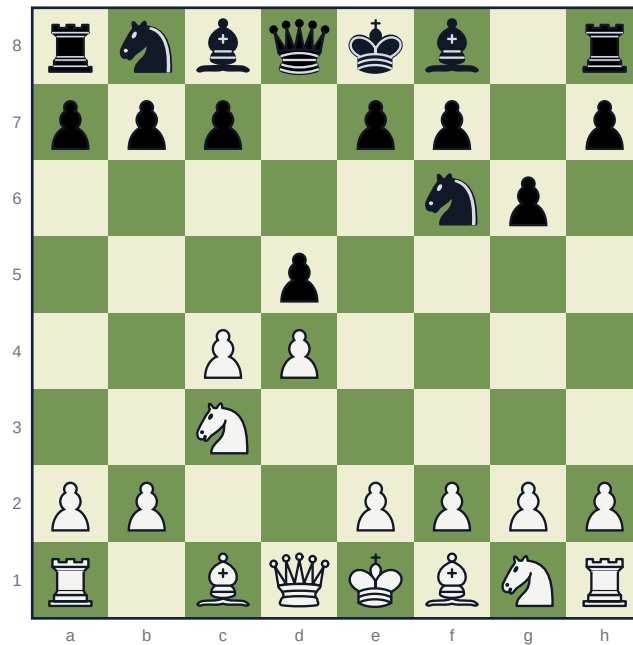
The black d-pawn is the signpost: d5 Gruenfeld, d6 King's Indian.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | The signpost

Which development sequence defines this repertoire branch?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | Queen pressure

Which rook move fits the position, and why is it more than queen harassment?



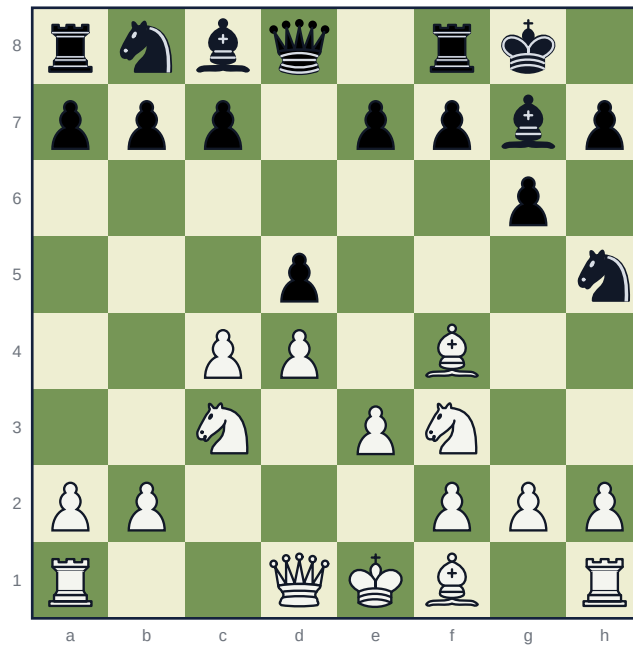
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Qa5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Bishop retreat

What is the repertoire retreat path and the strategic bargain?



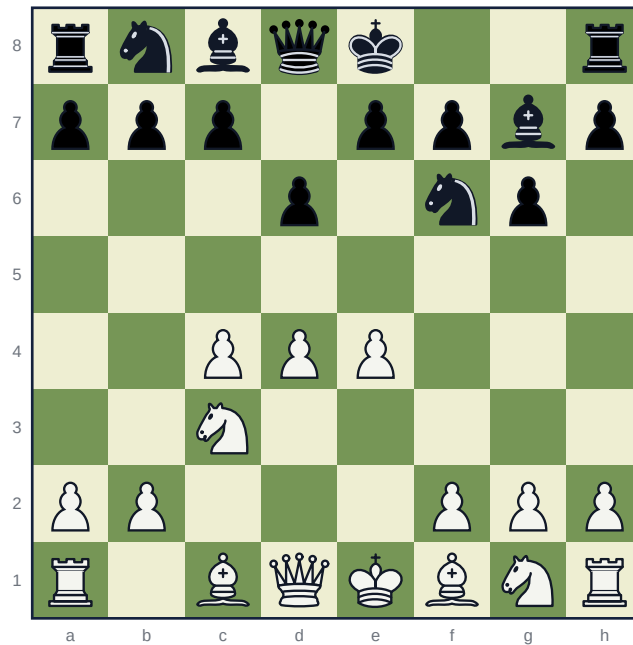
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 Nh5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Classify the pawn center

Why should White not keep using the Gruenfeld chapter?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | The signpost

This is the Gruenfeld. Play 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Bf4, then e3. White develops defenders of the center before expanding it.

TEST 02 | Queen pressure

Play 8.Rc1. The b1 knight and c1 bishop have moved, so the rook enters the c-file, supports c5, and prepares natural recovery after ...dxc4.

TEST 03 | Bishop retreat

Use 7.Bg5 h6 8.Bh4. Black gains bishop tempi but loosens dark squares with ...h6 and potentially ...g5. White regroupes with Nd2 and finishes development before attacking those pawns.

TEST 04 | Classify the pawn center

Black has chosen ...d6 rather than ...d5, creating a King's Indian shell. Continue 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be2 and use the King's Indian volume.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5: Black attacks the center immediately.	Develop the pieces that defend the center; trade a pawn before it costs a tempo.
Black has castled and strikes d4 with ...c5 before White is fully developed.	Open center: complete development, then use tempi on the queen.
Black supports d5 with ...c6 and delays the direct ...c5 break.	Solid ...c6: recover, castle, preserve bishop, then earn e4.
Black attacks d4 with ...c5 before committing the king.	Early ...c5: Nd2-b3 gains a queen tempo; e4 opens the center before Black castles.
Black uses the f6 knight to attack the repertoire bishop before striking the center.	Let Black spend pawn tempi; regroup, castle, then attack the fixed weakness.
Black captures c4 before White completes e3/Be2 development.	Capture on c4 concedes center: occupy e4, meet ...c5 with d5, stay tactically awake.
Black inserts ...a6 and ...b5 to gain space while keeping central options.	Rc1 anticipates the file; recover, retreat, castle, then undermine.
Black delays ...Bg7, inserts ...c6, or reaches ...d5 through a different order.	The black d-pawn is the signpost: d5 Gruenfeld, d6 King's Indian.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.